



B-52 strikes

From December 1965, the US stepped up its attacks on the trail by authorizing B-52 bombing. It is estimated that some 2 million tons of bombs were dropped on the Trail during the course of the war.

Battle of wits

US Air Force and Navy planes bombed the trail heavily, hunting trail workers and North Vietnamese troops going south to fight. It is estimated that some 30,000 people died on the trail over the course of the war, though some put the figure as high as 100,000. However, because much of the trail was hidden under jungle canopy, American pilots grew frustrated that they were risking their lives to bomb what was often just trees.

To address this, US planes sprayed defoliants over the jungle to rid the trees of foliage. They even engaged in cloud seeding—spraying clouds with silver iodide and lead iodide to create rain—in order to slow truck traffic by reducing visibility or washing out roads and bridges. Project Popeye, a top-secret cloud-seeding operation over the Trail between March 1967 and July 1972, sought to extend the monsoon season each year by a month or more.

The US military tried to locate the trail more precisely by planting motion and sound sensors to detect traffic, and also developed “people sniffers,” sensors designed to detect the smell of human urine and sweat. Army and Air Force pilots dropped leaflets in Vietnamese on the Trail, threatening more devastating bombing and urging workers and soldiers to desert.

Vietnamese trail workers found ingenious ways to undermine these efforts. They drove cattle down false trails to trigger motion and sound detectors, luring US bombers away from actual trail traffic. They hung bags of urine in trees far from the trail to fool the people sniffers. But mostly they worked diligently to repair by hand (or occasionally with heavy machinery) the damage wrought by bombs.